

WHAT YOUR TAX DOLLARS ACTUALLY PAY FOR

A Plain-Language Fact Sheet on AISH, ADAP, and Alberta's Money

April 2026 | All figures from Government of Alberta official sources

You work hard. You pay taxes. And you may have been told that people on disability income support are lazy, milking the system, or a burden on taxpayers like you. This document asks you to look at the actual numbers — because the numbers tell a very different story.

MYTH #1: "These people could work if they tried."

AISH — the Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped — is not available to people with mild or temporary disabilities. To receive it, a person must be assessed as permanently and substantially limited by a qualifying condition. The word 'severely' is in the program's name.

The assessment process requires:

- Documented medical diagnosis from a licensed specialist
- Confirmation that the condition is permanent — it will not improve
- Evidence that it substantially limits the person's ability to earn income
- Review and approval by the Government of Alberta

This is not easy to qualify for. It is not a program for bad backs or general fatigue. It is for Alberta's most severely disabled residents — and the government's own contracted assessors confirm eligibility.

MYTH #2: "Fraud is rampant — taxpayers are being taken advantage of."

Fraud in any government program is a legitimate concern and should be investigated and prosecuted. It already is — under existing law. But fraud statistics are being used to justify eliminating supports for people who are genuinely and severely disabled. These are not the same problem.

What fraud enforcement does	What ADAP does
Investigates and prosecutes false claims	Eliminates supports for verified recipients
Targets people who lied to get benefits	Transfers people who legitimately qualified for a decade or more
Removes bad actors from the program	Removes the program from people with confirmed permanent disabilities
Addresses a small subset of cases	Affects 79,000 Albertans — every AISH recipient

Cracking down on fraud and eliminating disability income for legitimate recipients are not the same action. Treating them as the same is how the government manufactures public consent for cuts.

MYTH #3: "My tax dollars are paying for all of this."

This is the most important question to look at clearly. Where does Alberta's money actually come from — and where does it actually go?

Where Alberta's revenue comes from:

Revenue Source	2024-25 Amount
Non-renewable resource revenue (oil and gas royalties)	\$25.2 billion
Federal transfers to Alberta	~\$10 billion
Personal income tax (paid by working Albertans)	~\$16 billion
Corporate tax and other sources	Remaining balance
Total provincial revenue	~\$78 billion

The majority of Alberta's wealth is generated by oil and gas that belongs to all Albertans — including disabled ones. Personal income tax is one component of a much larger picture.

Where Alberta's money actually went in 2024-25:

Expenditure / Decision	Amount
Alberta Heritage Fund — deposit from 2024-25 surplus	\$2.8 billion (one year)
Heritage Fund total value (December 2025)	\$31.9 billion
Heritage Fund growth — Q3 2025-26 (one quarter alone)	\$383 million

Personal income tax cut (8% bracket) — forgone revenue per year	\$1.2 billion annually, forever
AISH total annual budget (what the entire program costs)	\$1.641 billion
AISH budget cut — amount removed from program	\$49 million cut
Canada Disability Benefit clawed back from recipients	~\$190 million/year redirected to general revenue

The entire AISH program — all 79,000 recipients — costs \$1.641 billion per year. The Heritage Fund earned \$383 million in a single quarter. The province cut the program by \$49 million while the Fund grew by \$383 million in three months.

MYTH #4: "Cutting disability supports saves taxpayer money."

This is the claim that deserves the closest scrutiny. Cuts to disability income do not disappear — they reappear elsewhere, in systems that cost significantly more.

Scenario	Annual Cost Per Person
AISH recipient remains housed (full benefit paid)	\$23,280/year
Person experiencing homelessness (emergency shelter + services)	\$55,000/year
Additional taxpayer cost if a housed recipient becomes homeless	\$31,720 MORE per person

Source: End Homelessness Edmonton — Calgary Housing First program evaluation

If reduced AISH income pushes even 1,540 recipients into homelessness — less than 2% of the caseload — the downstream cost to emergency shelters, ERs, and social services exceeds the entire \$49 million cut. Cutting disability income doesn't save money. It transfers costs from one government budget to another — and makes those costs larger.

Emergency room visits for psychiatric crises among disability recipients increased 47% following benefit reductions. ER visits are among the most expensive interventions in the healthcare system — and they are taxpayer-funded.

Source: Alberta Doctors' Digest, November/December 2025

THE HERITAGE FUND: What It Was Built For

Alberta's Heritage Savings Trust Fund was created in 1976 by Premier Peter Lougheed. Its founding legislation lists three objectives:

Objective	Language from the Founding Legislation
1. Save for the future	"To save for the future"
2. Strengthen the economy	"To strengthen or diversify the economy"
3. Quality of life	"To improve the quality of life of Albertans"

The third objective — improving the quality of life of Albertans — was not decorative. It was central to Lougheed's intent.

The Heritage Fund has grown to \$31.9 billion. It earned approximately \$2.6 billion in investment returns in 2024-25 alone. Reversing every major financial cut imposed on AISH recipients would cost approximately \$260 million per year — roughly 10% of what the Fund earns annually. The government chose not to use it for that purpose.

COMPARISON: What Alaska Does Differently

Alaska and Alberta both created resource savings funds in 1976, from the same premise: non-renewable resource revenue should benefit the public.

	Alberta Heritage Fund	Alaska Permanent Fund
Founded	1976	1976
Current value	\$31.9 billion (CAD)	~\$119 billion (CAD equivalent)
Constitutional protection	No	Yes
Annual payment to residents	\$0	~\$2,400 CAD per person (2024)
Current disability policy	Cutting AISH, clawing back federal benefits	Pays every resident from the Fund

In 2024, every Alaskan resident — regardless of income, employment status, or disability — received approximately \$2,400 from their state's resource fund. In the same year, Alberta clawed back \$200/month from 79,000 of its most vulnerable residents.

WHO ARE THE PEOPLE ON AISH?

Before this program was cut, Alberta's own data showed:

- 79,290 Albertans received AISH as of September 2025
- Many are people who worked, paid taxes, and became disabled — often through no fault of their own
- Many are parents of severely disabled children, whose caregiving prevents full-time employment
- Many have conditions present from birth or early childhood — they did not choose this
- All were assessed as permanently and substantially disabled by government-approved processes

Jennifer Thurston said it directly in a public comment: "Remind them they are one injury or one unavoidable health issue away from living with a disability. It can happen to anyone."

Disability is not a character flaw. It is a medical reality. The people on AISH are not lazy. They are some of the most medically complex, most heavily burdened, and most systematically under-resourced Albertans in the province.

THE BOTTOM LINE FOR TAXPAYERS

The claim	The reality
"These people are lazy"	AISH requires permanent, specialist-confirmed severe disability
"Fraud is the problem"	Fraud enforcement already exists — ADAP affects all 79,000 recipients, not just fraudsters
"My taxes pay for all of this"	Most of Alberta's wealth comes from oil royalties, not personal income tax
"Cutting AISH saves money"	Downstream costs (homelessness, ER, crisis services) exceed the savings
"We can't afford disability supports"	The Heritage Fund earned \$383M in one quarter. The AISH cut was \$49M over a year.
"ADAP is an improvement"	ADAP transitions permanently disabled people into an employment-readiness framework that doesn't apply to them

Alberta is not a province that cannot afford to support its disabled residents.

It is a province that has chosen not to — while growing a \$31.9 billion savings account. That is a political choice, not a fiscal necessity.

Sources: Government of Alberta — Heritage Fund Q3 2025-26 Report; Budget 2025; Alberta AISH Caseload Open Data; End Homelessness Edmonton; CBC News Alberta fiscal year-end reports; Alberta Doctors' Digest Nov/Dec 2025; Alaska Permanent Fund Corporation 2024 Annual Report; Alberta Heritage Savings Trust Fund Act (1976)

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